resolution that criticised Soviet actions was a bad omen. Kabul was expecting undisputed support from New Delhi. On the other hand, many Afghan people—and not just the Mujahideen—who were unhappy with the Soviet intervention, grew critical of India's support.[84] Even senior Khalq leaders such as interior minister Sayed Mohammad Gulabzoi, minister of communications Mohammad Aslam Watanjar, and former spy chief Assadullah Sarwari, with whom India had developed good working relations before the events of December 1979, grew wary of India's pro-Parcham bias.[85] 'For the first time in three decades, anti-Indian sentiments have swelled up in Afghan hearts', the Indian media reported in February 1980.[86]

The Soviet withdrawal from Afghanistan in 1989 and the end of the Cold War in 1991 shifted India's position on Afghanistan from partisanship towards Pakistan to a more conciliatory approach. Receding global pressure and interest in Afghanistan shifted the strategic fulcrum of India's Afghanistan dilemma to regional and domestic politics. Though Pakistan had always been a potent factor, its emergence as the most powerful external actor in Kabul by the early 1990s augmented its relevance in India's Afghanistan policy proportionately. The only difference between the 1980s and 1990s was that these debates were not couched in ideological terms in the latter decade. They were, essentially, conceptual in nature. As detailed in the next chapter, the partisans were staunchly anti-Pakistan in their operational outlook and wanted to deal only with those Afghan political and military factions who shared this view. The conciliators were open to engaging with all Afghan factions regardless of their relations with and attitude towards Pakistan. India's debates on these lines evolved, slowly, during the 1980s. The sources of this change were same as before, i.e. India's desire to strike a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, evolving international political environment, and Afghanistan's domestic political scenario. The following two sections detail the evolution of these policy debates by delving into India's diplomatic initiatives with Moscow and Washington on one hand, and with Afghanistan on the other.

Leaning tower of Delhi